Designing Evaluation to Drive Outcomes and Create an Ongoing Learning Community in NAZ

Scott McConnell & Lauren Martin
University of Minnesota
Greg Owen & Ellen Shelton
Wilder Research

Introductions

Why do evaluation?

- Our primary purpose in doing evaluation is *to make sure we are making progress toward NAZ's goal:*

  To build a culture of achievement in a geographic zone in North Minneapolis to assure all youth graduate from high school college-ready.
- To the extent we can, we also want to discover ways that work here – and that might work in other communities

Two Functions of Evaluation

- *Process Evaluation (Internal Evaluation)* Describing NAZ's internal workings to ensure that things are happening that will make a difference
- *Outcome Evaluation (External Evaluation)* Describing the results of NAZ efforts with independent assessments of results

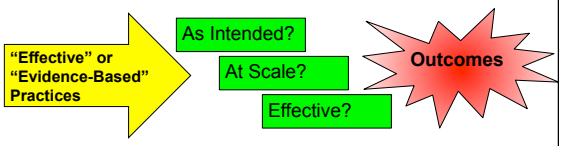
NAZ Evaluation General Principles

1. Child and Family Focused in the ZONE
2. Identify and Lift Up Excellence
3. Information/Data to support the operation of NAZ
4. Methods and Data Collection are Participatory and Context Relevant

Overview of "evaluation"



Overview of "evaluation"



Operating Principles for Evaluation

1. Transparent
2. Accountable
3. Rigorous
4. Directly relevant to improving outcomes
5. Actionable
6. Efficient

Evaluation Activities to Date

- Outcomes and indicators of progress
- Partnership Survey/Network Analysis
- Community Survey ("Micro-climate" in the zone)
- "Best Estimates" of baselines for zone-wide indicators (based on secondary data)
- Telling the Story of NAZ – Narrative and Qualitative Evaluation
- Evaluation Plans for NAZ Program Development in 2010

Activities to Date: Outcomes and Indicators

- Started last fall – worked with management and collaborative partners
- Identified desired outcomes of NAZ and indicators along the way
- Also what are NAZ activities to make those happen
- Logic model – in revision now
- Helps us know what we need to measure

Activities to Date: Partnership Survey & Network Analysis

Jan.2010 starting point measures for:

- The partnership experience
  - Are important factors working?
- Building a coordinated pipeline of services
  - Are providers well aligned with each other?
  - With NAZ?
  - Working with each other?

Activities to Date: Community Survey

- Measure 'micro-climate' of achievement and other NAZ indicators and needs
- Representative, random sample
- Trained the NAZ Engagement team as social science interviewers
- 400 household surveys by October



Activities to Date: "Best Estimates"

Where we are now on key indicators:

A snap-shot of our starting points in the Zone

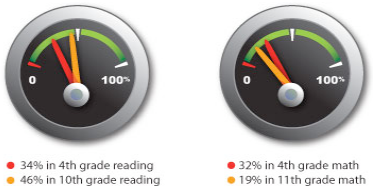
- Based on best estimates and available data for now
- Will replace with more accurate data soon
- Will develop data sharing agreements with schools, city, county (and others?)

Indicator 1: The percentage of NAZ children who enter kindergarten ready to learn



In the fall of 2009, 26 percent of NAZ children* entered Kindergarten ready to learn**

Indicator 2:
In the spring of the 2008-09 school year, the following percentages of NAZ children* were at grade level**:



34% in reading	4th grade	32% in math
46% in reading	10-11th grade	19% in math

Activities to Date: "Telling the Story"

Capture and measure the intangible impacts of NAZ on culture, goals and aspirations:

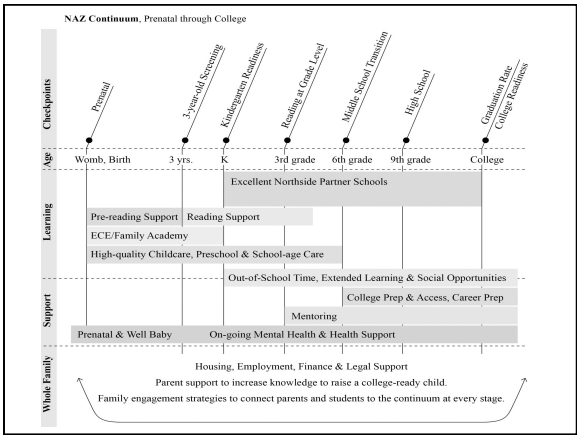
- Families in the Zone
- Among staff and NAZ organizations

Activities to Date: Evaluation Plans for NAZ Program Development

External and Internal Evaluation Plans

External Evaluation Progress on Outcomes

The External Evaluation will document NAZ and its partners' success at helping children move toward graduating from high school ready to attend college



Internal Evaluation

The Internal Evaluation will document the extent to which NAZ and its partners implement high-quality services as intended, as widely as needed, and with the impact needed to make a difference

Internal Evaluation's Big Questions

- Are our plans *strong, promising, and likely to contribute* to NAZ's goal?
- Are our plans *being implemented as they were intended and designed?*
- Are our plans *reaching enough, and the right, individuals?*
- Are our plans *producing the results we need?*

Strong, Promising Plans

- Making plans, and selecting interventions, that we think are likely to help
  - "Evidence-Based Practices"
  - Best practices
  - Logical analyses
- Action Teams have generated these plans
- With Action Teams, we will be completing preliminary "peer reviews" of these plans

Are our Plans Implemented as Intended?

- What good is a plan that doesn't get used?
  - Action Teams' plans turned into operational, observable 'tasks'
  - We will develop a way to monitor completion of these tasks, provide feedback to individuals, programs, and NAZ about "fidelity" of implementation
  - When necessary, individuals or programs or NAZ will "redirect" intervention to match intended plan

Are Our Plans Going to Scale?

- What good is a plan if it doesn't reach enough, or the right, individuals?
  - NAZ management and program partners will set goals for participation
  - NAZ program partners will track participation and progress in plan implementation
  - When necessary, individuals, programs, or NAZ will redouble and/or change efforts to increase participation

Are our Plans Making a Difference?

- With Action Teams, Program Partners, and NAZ, we will identify "along the way" measures of success – progress measures for NAZ goal and checkpoints
- We will design and collect ways to monitor this progress
- When plans are being implemented as intended and at scale, *and progress is not being made*, NAZ Action Teams and partners will revise plans and intervention

Internal Evaluation – All Together Now

- NAZ has organized to produce ambitious and rigorous plans for action and intervention
- NAZ will monitor and, when needed, act to make sure these plans are implemented well
- NAZ will monitor and, when needed, act to make sure all eligible children have an opportunity to benefit from these plans
- NAZ will be a learning organization – when our intended plans don't work, we will change to plans that do

Conclusion, Questions, and Discussion